

AP European History: The Complete Exam Guide

All 9 units explained, the SAQ, DBQ and LEQ playbook with a sample thesis, the historical thinking skills, and 10 hard source-based practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.

**3:15**

hours total,
including reading time

55+5

multiple-choice +
written questions

25%

of your score is
the DBQ alone

73–74%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Two sections, four tasks

Your AP score (1–5) combines multiple choice, short answers and two essays. Most tasks are source-based, covering European history from about 1450 to the present.

40%

MCQ • 55 questions

20%

SAQ • 3 questions

25%

DBQ • 1 essay

15%

LEQ

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
IA • Multiple choice	40% of score 55 minutes 55 questions	Sets of usually 3–4 questions built around a primary or secondary source: texts, images, charts or maps.
IB • Short answer	20% of score 40 minutes 3 questions	Q1 (secondary source or sources) and Q2 (primary source) are required; then choose Q3 or Q4 (no source). Each has three parts.
II • Document-based question	25% of score 60 min (incl. 15-min reading) 1 essay	Write an argument using 7 documents plus your own knowledge. The DBQ covers 1450–2001.
II • Long essay	15% of score 40 minutes 1 essay	Choose one of three prompts, each covering a different span of time periods, and write an argument.

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

SCORED WITH RUBRICS

Essays use the same rubric every year

The DBQ (7 points) and long essay (6 points) are scored on thesis, contextualization, evidence and analysis. Learning the rubric is the fastest way to raise your score.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 15 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.

SECTION I

02 Multiple choice & short answer

55 multiple-choice questions in 55 minutes (one minute each), then 3 short-answer questions in 40 minutes. Most questions use a source.

55

source-based multiple-choice questions

1:00

minute per multiple-choice question

3

short-answer questions, 3 parts each

0

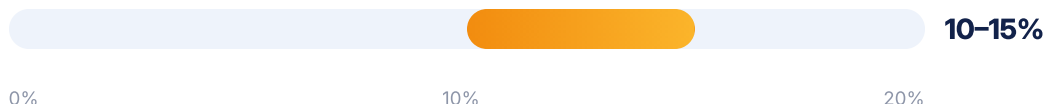
points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

How the exam is weighted by unit

College Board gives a range for each unit's share of the exam. Bars show minimum to maximum.

Units 1–9

Every unit carries the same range

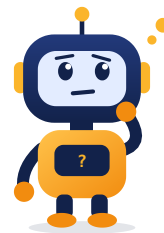


What this means for your study time: All nine units carry the same 10–15% range, so there is no unit to skip. Spread your review evenly and prioritize the ones you know least.

Strategies for multiple choice and short answers

- **Read the source line first:** author, date and audience tell you the context before you read the text.
- **Answer the question asked.** "Which development most directly caused..." means a cause, not just a related event.
- **For short answers, use ACE:** Answer the question, Cite specific evidence, Explain how it supports your answer.
- **One part, one paragraph.** Label each short-answer part (a), (b), (c) and answer in 2–3 sentences.
- **Be specific:** name people, laws, events and dates. Vague answers rarely earn the point.
- **Never leave a blank.** Guess, flag and move on at the one-minute mark.

Short answers need **specific evidence**. "There were reforms" scores nothing; naming one reform can.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 9 units, in plain English

Everything on the exam fits into these units.

UNIT 1 10–15%	Renaissance & Exploration c. 1450–1648 Know: Italian and Northern Renaissance; humanism; the printing press; new monarchies; causes and effects of exploration and the Columbian Exchange.	UNIT 2 10–15%	Age of Reformation c. 1450–1648 Know: Luther, Calvin and the Protestant Reformation; the Catholic Reformation; wars of religion; the Thirty Years' War.
UNIT 3 10–15%	Absolutism & Constitutionalism c. 1648–1815 Know: Louis XIV and absolutism; the English Civil War and Glorious Revolution; the Dutch Republic; Russia under Peter the Great.	UNIT 4 10–15%	Scientific, Philosophical & Political Developments c. 1648–1815 Know: the Scientific Revolution; the Enlightenment; enlightened absolutism; changes in population, agriculture and consumer culture.
UNIT 5 10–15%	Conflict, Crisis & Reaction in the Late 18th Century c. 1648–1815 Know: the French Revolution and its phases; Napoleon; the Congress of Vienna; Romanticism.	UNIT 6 10–15%	Industrialization & Its Effects c. 1815–1914 Know: the spread of industrialization; social classes and urban life; liberalism, socialism and Marxism; revolutions of 1848.
UNIT 7 10–15%	19th-Century Perspectives & Political Developments c. 1815–1914 Know: nationalism; Italian and German unification; new imperialism; Darwin and modern thought; mass politics.	UNIT 8 10–15%	20th-Century Global Conflicts c. 1914–present Know: World War I; the Russian Revolution; interwar crises and fascism; World War II and the Holocaust.
UNIT 9 10–15%	Cold War & Contemporary Europe c. 1914–present Know: the Cold War division of Europe; decolonization; European integration and the EU; the collapse of communism; recent challenges.		

◆ The historical thinking skills

Sourcing

Analyze point of view, purpose, audience and situation.

Contextualization

Place an event in its broader historical setting.

Comparison

Explain similarities and differences.

Causation & CCOT

Explain causes, effects, continuity and change.

SECTION II

04 The DBQ & the long essay

100 minutes for two essays. Both are scored with fixed rubrics, so you can practice for exactly what earns points.

Thesis 1

Context 1

Evidence 3

Analysis & reasoning 2

DBQ rubric: 7 points. The long essay uses the same rows but 2 evidence points (6 in total).

DBQ

Document-based question

7 points • 60 minutes

Use at least **4 documents** to support an argument for full evidence credit, add one piece of **outside evidence**, and explain **sourcing** for at least 2 documents.

Group documents into 2–3 categories that each prove part of your thesis.

LEQ

Long essay question

6 points • 40 minutes

No documents: the evidence comes from your own knowledge. Choose the prompt carefully, then argue a clear line of reasoning.

Pick the prompt for which you know the most specific evidence.

Th

Thesis (1 point)

Historically defensible claim

One or two sentences that make a claim and set out a line of reasoning. It can be in the introduction or conclusion.

"Although X, Y mainly because A and B" shows complexity from the start.

Cx

Contextualization (1 point)

The bigger picture

Describe broader developments before, during or after the period that relate to the prompt, in several sentences.

Write it as your opening paragraph so you don't forget it.

◆ A time plan for the 100 minutes

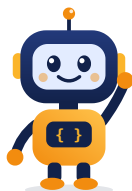
Read docs
15 min

Write DBQ
45 min

Plan
LEQ
5 min

Write LEQ
35 min

The 15-minute reading period is built into the recommended 60 minutes for the DBQ.



The **complexity point** is the hardest. Earn it by analyzing multiple variables, qualifying your argument, or connecting across periods.

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

05

Anatomy of a strong DBQ

Here is a DBQ-style prompt, a strong opening and one body paragraph, annotated to show where points come from.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (DBQ style): Evaluate the extent to which the Protestant Reformation changed the relationship between religious and political authority in Europe from 1517 to 1648. (*Sample paragraph references hypothetical documents.*)

Sample opening and body paragraph

① In the early 1500s, the Catholic Church held enormous spiritual and political influence across Europe, but humanism and the printing press were already encouraging people to question its practices.

② **Thesis:** The Reformation greatly strengthened rulers at the expense of the papacy, as princes gained control over religion within their states, although religious division also triggered destructive wars that rulers could not easily control.

③ German princes used Lutheranism to assert independence. Document 4, a prince's letter to the emperor, defends his right to choose his territory's faith. ④ Because he wrote to a Catholic emperor, the prince framed his choice as a matter of conscience rather than power. ⑤ The Peace of Augsburg (1555) later confirmed this principle: *cuius regio, eius religio*.

- ① **Contextualization** sets up the broader situation before the thesis.
- ② **Thesis** makes a defensible claim with a line of reasoning.
- ③ **Document evidence** is used to *support* a point, not just summarized.
- ④ **Sourcing** explains why the author's purpose or point of view matters.
- ⑤ **Outside evidence** adds a specific fact not in the documents.

Five habits for every history essay

1

Underline every task verb in the prompt before you plan.

2

Write a defensible thesis in your first paragraph.

3

Back every claim with specific evidence, then explain it.

4

Keep 2 minutes to reread and fix unclear sentences.

5

Stuck? Answer each part separately in order. Partial credit is real.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

Just **summarize** each document! (Don't.)



01 Restating the prompt as a thesis

A thesis must take a position and give reasons. Repeating the question earns no point.

02 Listing documents

"Document 1 says... Document 2 says..." is summary. Use documents as evidence for your argument.

03 Sourcing by labeling

"The author is a merchant" isn't enough. Explain **how** that affects the document's message.

04 One-sentence context

Contextualization needs several sentences about the broader situation, connected to the prompt.

05 Outside evidence from the documents

Outside evidence must be a specific fact that is **not** in any document.

06 Wrong time period

Evidence from outside the prompt's dates doesn't count. Check the years before writing.

07 Vague SAQ answers

Short answers need a specific example and an explanation, not a general statement.

08 Running out of time on the DBQ

Watch the clock. A rushed LEQ costs more than a slightly shorter DBQ.

09 Presentism

Judge events by their own time's context, and avoid "always" or "never" claims.

10 Skipping the conclusion

A conclusion is a second chance to state the thesis or earn the complexity point.

Quick self-check: can you explain one cause of the French Revolution, one effect of the Congress of Vienna, and one difference between liberalism and socialism? If not, review Units 5 and 6.

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Shift the months to match your teacher's pacing, and write at least one timed essay every two weeks.



- Sep – Oct**
1450–1648
 - Units 1–2**
Renaissance, exploration and Reformation. Practice sourcing religious and political documents.
- Nov – Dec**
1648–1815
 - Units 3–5**
Absolutism, Scientific Revolution, Enlightenment and the French Revolution. Write your first DBQ.
- Jan – Feb**
1815–1914
 - Units 6–7**
Industrialization, ideologies, nationalism and imperialism. A timed DBQ every two weeks.
- Mar – Apr**
1914–present
 - Units 8–9**
World wars, the Cold War and European integration. Alternate DBQs and long essays.
- Early May**
Sharpen
 - Full timed sections**
Full Section I and both essays under timing. Review the rubric and traps list.
- Exam day**
May
 - AP Euro exam • Bluebook**
Sleep well, charge your device, and use the checklist at the end of this guide.

• The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: one timed DBQ plus 28 multiple-choice questions	List your two weakest periods
3 weeks out	Review weak periods; write one SAQ set daily	Specific evidence in every answer
2 weeks out	Full 3-hour-15-minute practice exam	Finish all four tasks on time
Final week	Light review: rubric, key turning points, traps list	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original source-based questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Give yourself **15 minutes** for all ten, then check page 11.

1 UNIT 1 • CAUSATION

Which development most directly helped Protestant ideas spread rapidly after 1517?

- A The Columbian Exchange
- B The Scientific Revolution
- C The Congress of Vienna
- D The printing press

2 UNIT 2 • CONTINUITY & CHANGE

The Peace of Westphalia (1648) is significant mainly because it:

- A restored the pope's authority over all of Europe
- B recognized the sovereignty of states and largely ended the era of major religious wars
- C unified Germany under Prussia
- D ended the Hundred Years' War

3 UNIT 3 • COMPARISON

England after 1688 differed from France under Louis XIV in that England:

- A had no monarch
- B had a stronger standing army
- C had a monarch whose power was limited by Parliament
- D banned all Protestant churches

4 UNIT 4 • CONTEXTUALIZATION

Enlightenment thinkers' confidence in reason was most directly influenced by:

- A the Scientific Revolution's use of observation and natural laws
- B the Black Death
- C the Counter-Reformation's Index of Forbidden Books
- D the spread of Romanticism

5 UNIT 5 • SOURCING

"What is the Third Estate? Everything. What has it been until now in the political order? Nothing. What does it want to be? Something."

Abbé Sieyès, pamphlet, January 1789

The pamphlet was written mainly to:

- A defend the privileges of the clergy
- B call for the restoration of absolute monarchy
- C argue that commoners deserved greater political power on the eve of the Estates-General
- D support Napoleon's rise to power

6 UNIT 6 • CAUSATION

Which was a major effect of industrialization on European society in the 1800s?

- A The decline of cities
- B The growth of an urban working class and a larger middle class
- C The end of child labor everywhere by 1820
- D A return to subsistence farming

7 UNIT 7 • COMPARISON

The unifications of Italy and Germany were similar in that both:

- A were achieved entirely through peaceful votes
- B created communist states
- C were opposed by nationalists
- D were led by a powerful state using diplomacy and war (Piedmont-Sardinia and Prussia)

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

8 UNIT 8 • CAUSATION

Which factor best explains the appeal of fascist movements in the interwar period?

- A Economic crisis, fear of communism and resentment of the post-war settlement
- B Prosperity and stability after 1918
- C The success of the League of Nations
- D The spread of liberal democracy in Eastern Europe

9 UNIT 9 • CONTINUITY & CHANGE

Which best describes a change in Western Europe after 1945?

- A A return to the colonial empires of 1900
- B Increasing economic cooperation that led toward the European Union
- C The spread of absolute monarchy
- D Withdrawal from all international alliances

10 UNIT 9 • CAUSATION

Which development most directly contributed to the collapse of communist governments in Eastern Europe in 1989?

- A Gorbachev's reforms and refusal to use force to prop up satellite governments
- B The Marshall Plan
- C The Cuban Missile Crisis
- D The Berlin Airlift

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	D	Printed pamphlets and Bibles spread Luther's ideas quickly and cheaply across Europe, beyond what church authorities could control.
2	B	Westphalia ended the Thirty Years' War and established the principle of state sovereignty, reducing religion as a cause of major wars between states.
3	C	After the Glorious Revolution and the English Bill of Rights, Parliament limited the Crown. Louis XIV ruled as an absolute monarch.
4	A	Scientists such as Newton showed the natural world followed rational laws, inspiring philosophers to apply reason to society and government.
5	C	Sieyès argued that the Third Estate, the vast majority of the population, deserved real political power as the Estates-General met.
6	B	Factories drew workers to cities, creating a large working class and expanding the middle class of managers and professionals.
7	D	Cavour (Piedmont-Sardinia) and Bismarck (Prussia) used diplomacy and short wars to unify their nations.
8	A	Depression, fear of communist revolution and anger at the Treaty of Versailles helped fascists win support.
9	B	From the Coal and Steel Community to the EEC and later the EU, Western Europe moved steadily toward economic integration.
10	A	Gorbachev's glasnost and perestroika and his decision not to intervene allowed popular movements to topple communist governments.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Re-learn the turning points of each period and practice sourcing.

10 KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 73–74% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP European History, and about 14–16% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

73–74%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

14–16%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Plan your time: **1 min** per multiple-choice question, **~13 min** per short answer, **60 min** for the DBQ and **40 min** for the long essay
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Memorize the **DBQ and LEQ rubric rows**
- ☐ Practice typing a full essay in 40 minutes before exam day

In the essays: open with context, state a defensible thesis with reasons, use documents as evidence with sourcing, add specific outside evidence, and explain how every piece supports your argument.



ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 AP TUTORING

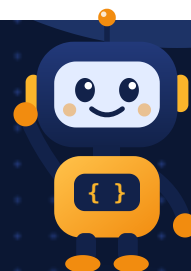
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◆ Contact us

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